

The Noble Black-Lipped One

Ārya Kṛṣṇāyoṣṭha · Toh 763 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 763 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Kṛṣṇāyoṣṭha and in Tibetan as the Noble Black-Lipped One, which may be rendered into English as the Noble Dhāraṇī of the Black-Lipped One. It belongs to the class of dhāraṇī or incantation literature and takes the form of a discourse delivered by the Buddha to the Venerable Ānanda and a assembly of nāga kings, set in a resting place among jambū trees, with the nāga kings addressed out of the Buddha's compassion for the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. The text is relatively brief and is concerned with the transmission of a protective dhāraṇī, situating its teaching within a narrative frame that invokes the authority of the Buddha's direct speech.

They praised what the Blessed One had declared. Thus concludes the noble dhāraṇī of the Iron-Lipped One.

In the language of India: Ārya Kṛṣṇāyoṣṭha. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Black-Lipped One.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in a resting place amidst a thicket of jambū trees. Then the Blessed One addressed the Venerable Ānanda, saying: "Ānanda, go to that place in Jambudvīpa." The Venerable One replied, "Blessed One, it shall be done as you say," and the Venerable Ānanda listened to the Blessed One's instructions.

Then, out of compassion for the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa, the Blessed One directed his words to the nāga kings: Anavatapta, Ocean, Joyful, Steadfast, Boundless, Conch-Keeper, Lustrous, Ela-Leafed, Tadpole, the nāga king Lightning-Sender, the nāga king Water-God, the nāga king Cloud-Summoner, the nāga king Nine-Headed, the nāga king Seven-Headed, the nāga king Five-Headed, Six-Headed, Three-Headed, Two-Headed, and Thousand-Headed.

The Blessed One cast upon them these words:

Anante. Vināne. Biśikiśi. Aguvi. Gure re. Hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ. Phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ. Stambhaya. Bhañjaya. Vasa śarīrāṇi. Mahritra. Matra maṇi svāhā.

With that first mantra-section, the nāgas were stirred and fell into a swoon.

They said: "Blessed One, we shall not obstruct or prevent the drying out of crops, fruits, medicines, trees and shrubs, sprouts, leaves, and flowers. We shall send down rain in its proper season. We shall cause grasses, trees, and forests to grow. We shall not harm or impede the prosperity of the people of Jambudvīpa. We shall not harm sentient beings. But if any of us nāgas should transgress the command of the Blessed One, may our bodies become shriveled, may we have no resting place, may our bodies become rough, may we be afflicted with leprosy, festering sores, and skin blemishes, may our heads split open, and may our hearts be pierced."

Then hundreds of thousands of elemental spirits who were devoted to the Blessed One came forward on behalf of all sentient beings and said: "Those among them who bear hostile minds toward you are coming to do great harm to you. Drive them out! Drive them out! Drive them away at once! Let those who harbor aversion toward you be destroyed. And as for those who hold loving minds and wish no harm, who desire to protect — enter into their bodies!"

Then the Buddha, compassionate toward the world, declared:

Sumu sumu. Sumu sumu. Sumu ru. Sumu ru. Sumu ru. Sumu ru. Sumu ru. Sumu ru. Muru muru. Muru muru. Miri miri svāhā.

Gods, nāgas, asuras, and yakṣas — both male and female — send down swiftly a continuous rain of rain as desired. Gather water from every nāga dwelling, nine portions in all, set each portion apart, sprinkle them with white mustard seed, and bestow water. When the mantra is complete, convey it to the nāga dwellings. Rain shall fall just as desired.

Then the Buddha, compassionate toward the world, possessed of supreme intention for the benefit of sentient beings, abiding in loving-kindness, endowed with compassion, abiding in joy, abiding in equanimity, spoke:

Kṣibhrani niragadchatā svāhā. Nāga yu yu svāhā.

Gaze at the clouds, look out in the four directions, make prostrations, and recite fifty times: rain will certainly fall swiftly.

When bringing down rain, go to a place not frequented by nāgas. Wash the body with fragrant water, seek the three white foods, and avoid meat, alcohol, onions, and garlic. Holding a mind filled with loving-kindness, face east, and make supplication to the noble ones:

Ri pu ri bu. Pā la ya thā. Hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā. Vajra vajra jvāla ya svāhā. Sarva duśaṃ na viraṃśaka svāhā. Garuḍa hṛiti svāhā.

Draw a tiger in blue ink at the top of a flag. Display a blue victory banner. The one holding the mantra wears a blue seat cloth, blue garments, with the feet also spread apart in blue. Blue tormas offerings for the gods. Place four vases filled with water at the four corners of the maṇḍala. In the center, place the image of the nāga king of the ocean. On the eastern lotus, place the three-headed nāga king. On the southern lotus, place the seven-headed nāga king. On the western lotus, place the nine-headed nāga king. On the northern lotus, place the five-headed nāga. Also place what arises from the ritual-activity texts.

Oṃ he hu la phaṭ phaṭ. Hūṃ bi dza ya phaṭ phaṭ. Nāga li jvāla. Śad śad. Jvāli bikṛita. Vajra vajra la mahā pala pāryā para kṛidha. Da ra ci. Pra me ru. Phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ du.

The very instant this dhāraṇī is uttered, the great earth shall quake. Sixty trillion great nāga kings shall plunge head-first into pits, trembling violently, falling senseless, turning back from their wrongdoing, and weeping.

Then the nāga kings addressed the Blessed One with lament, saying: "This mantra burns the nāgas most terribly. It is most unfit." And the Blessed One declared: "Let the nāga kings bring benefit, happiness, good harvest, protection, and shelter to the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. Let the fields be filled to the very brim. Bring abundant crops to fruition. Do no harm to humans and non-humans alike. Let the stream of rain be poured down. And yet you yourselves shall be freed from long-lasting suffering and from all nāga-afflictions. May those of you with many legs be well. May those of you with four legs be well. May those of you with two legs be well. May those of you with no legs be well. May you travel the road in well-being. May those who return also be in well-being. May you not come to sorrow."

Buddhas, along with thousands of divine beings,
completely surrounding them, have come forth —
let those possessed of hostile minds be driven away,
let those whose nature is compassion draw near.

Through the aims of causing rain to fall upon this continent,
may those who dwell upon the earth and in the intermediate sky
show loving-kindness toward all living beings.

When drought appears without rain,
recite the first section of mantras one hundred times.
The middle, fifty and fifty times.
The last, seven times.

While gazing at the clouds, recite softly in between so that no one notices. If the count is exceeded, there will be hail — a great transgression. Since this strikes the nāgas at their vital points, it is a great transgression. Do not apply the recitation count repeatedly time after time. Within one day, or two days, or five days at most, it is impossible for a continuous stream of rain not to fall.

May the Dharma-King, free from old age and death,
may the aspirational prayers of all be swiftly fulfilled.

Thus did the Blessed One speak. The venerable Ānanda and those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble dhāraṇī of the Black Iron-Beak is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The sūtra opening names Ānanda but the Tibetan gives his name as "Kun dga' bo," a standard Tibetan rendering of Ānanda, so this is treated straightforwardly. The nāga king Anavatapta (Ma dros pa) is the famous cool-lake nāga king of Indian Buddhist geography, identified with confidence. Several of the nāga epithets and the mantra syllables are transliterated rather than translated, as is standard for dhāraṇī literature. The mantra syllables are rendered as close phonetic approximations of the Tibetan; their Sanskrit originals, where reconstructible, are standard dhāraṇī formulae. The passage "mnyas bor shig" has been rendered "directed his words" with the sense that the Blessed One cast or aimed the mantra passage at the nāgas, which fits both the ritual context and the grammar. The phrase "mgos 'gas pa dang snying 'drul bar gyur cig" meaning splitting heads and piercing hearts is a conventional curse formula in nāga-coercion dhāraṇī literature.

- The phrase rendered "drawing a tiger in blue ink at the top of a flag" is a ritual instruction that is slightly compressed in the Tibetan. The term translated "flag" literally means "a flag at the top" and the "blue" qualifier applies consistently through the entire ritual setup passage — blue banner, blue seat, blue garments, blue feet-spread, blue torma — reflecting the nāga-rain ritual's color coding. The rendering "feet also spread apart in blue" is somewhat opaque in the original and may refer to blue-painted or blue-cloth-covered footwear or a floor mat; the exact referent is uncertain.

The colophon epithet translated "Black Iron-Beak" refers to the title of the dhāraṇī text — the "noble dhāraṇī of Black Iron-Beak" — likely evoking a garuda-like or crow-like deity associated with nāga subjugation. The Sanskrit behind this title is not reconstructed in the Tibetan colophon and the precise Sanskrit original is uncertain.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.